

Exactly, that is where I found myself. The prior summer, I took a break after graduating business school to travel through Europe. While traveling, I bumped into a friend of mine who I knew from Berkeley. He had gone to business school at USC, while I went to business school at USF. We got together after we returned. We started talking about our job searches, and by coincidence, it turned out we had both interviewed for the same job. He told me they had hired someone else from Berkeley; neither one of us got the job.

They never gave you the courtesy of a call to tell you that someone else got the job?

No, they didn't, but it turned out the other person was hired as an investment banker, which was not the position I had interviewed for. After I got back, I called Hoefer and said, "I'm going to be in the Burlingame area next week," which was a complete lie. "Do you mind if I stop by to say hello again?" Hoefer said it was fine for me to come by.

I went in and ended up having lunch with Bob Arnett, who was the other founding partner in the firm. At lunch, I was talking a lot about Buffett and the companies Hoefer & Arnett were invested in because at that point I felt well-versed enough to hold my own on these topics. At one point in our conversation, Arnett looked at me and said, "Are you telling me all of this because you are interested in it or because you think it's what I want to hear?"

"A little bit of both," I answered.

The next week I got an offer from them to be a broker.

Were you concerned that it was a sales position?

I didn't care; I just wanted to get my foot in the door. It was a very small firm. I hoped that if I applied myself, I wouldn't be stuck as a broker. As it turned out, I was only a broker for about two months.

Once you started there, what did they have you do?

They had me cold calling.

Was it difficult?

Yes, it was very difficult. Some of the people on my call list were dead.